TRACKOWLS / DIGITAL CONTENT PROTECTION

# Digital piracy.
# Real consequences.

A practical report on piracy exposure, commercial risk, evidence quality and protection decisions.

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EDITORIAL PURPOSE

## Clear evidence.
## Better protection decisions.

This TrackOwls report brings together attributed secondary research and original operational guidance for rights holders. It is designed to help you ask better questions about piracy exposure, commercial risk and enforcement outcomes.

This is an editorial synthesis, not a TrackOwls survey or a client-results study. Research figures retain their original dates and scope.

### Measure the threat. Protect the value.

Piracy is a commercial challenge as well as an infringement problem. A useful protection programme connects the content at risk, the evidence behind each finding and the business window in which action matters.

### Three priorities for rights holders

For production teams, the priority is release integrity: preventing a leak from undermining the sequence of theatrical, transactional and licensed windows. For OTT services, it is catalogue access and integrity: distinguishing unauthorized distribution from ordinary demand. For live events, it is timing: an action during a broadcast serves a different purpose from a removal confirmed after the audience has moved on.

### Count evidence before counting impact

Raw search results, verified infringements, enforcement submissions and confirmed outcomes are different measures. Combining them into a single takedown number makes reports harder to interpret. A sound reporting process preserves the distinction and describes coverage gaps.

## Revenue loss needs its own analysis

A pirate visit is not automatically a lost sale. Commercial estimates need assumptions about legal availability, existing paid access, duplicate consumption and willingness to pay. Financial exposure should be expressed as a range with the assumptions visible.

01 / RESEARCH LANDSCAPE

# What the published numbers can tell us

Published research offers a starting point for understanding scale. It cannot replace asset-level evidence, nor can unrelated estimates be combined into one market-loss figure.

| 216.3bn | $29.2bn | $28.3bn |
|---|---|---|
| **Global piracy website visits** Source [1] | **Estimated annual U.S. revenue loss** Source [2] | **Potential annual sports revenue** Source [3] |

## Traffic is a demand signal

MUSO's 2024 report measured 216.3 billion global piracy website visits across TV, film, publishing, music and software. TV accounted for 96.8 billion visits and film for 24.3 billion. These are visits to measured websites, not unique viewers, completed streams or paid transactions. [1]

## Economic models answer a different question

The 2019 U.S. Chamber / NERA analysis estimated at least $29.2 billion in annual U.S. revenue losses associated with global online video piracy. Its geography, year and macroeconomic approach make it a historical benchmark, rather than a current loss estimate for an individual service. [2]

## Opportunity is not the same as loss

A 2021 Synamedia / Ampere model estimated up to $28.3 billion in potential annual sports revenue from reducing piracy, including $5.4 billion for OTT sports. The result depends on conversion assumptions and is not a measured loss or a guaranteed financial recovery. [3]

**TRACKOWLS PERSPECTIVE**

Always preserve the year, geography, metric and method beside a headline number.

02 / FILM & PRODUCTION

# A release is a sequence of value windows

Production investment is monetized through a sequence of rights, territories and release dates. Protection should reflect that sequence instead of treating every unauthorized copy as equally urgent.

## Before release: prepare the evidence

Maintain a controlled asset register covering titles, alternate names, approved distributors and territorial rights. Identify screeners and other sensitive copies. Prepare ownership evidence and escalation contacts before a suspected leak needs urgent verification.

## During release: prioritize the window

A verified pre-release copy, a theatrical recording and a post-release re-upload may demand different responses. Record the first observation time, copy type, language, territory and distribution channel. Use those attributes to prioritize investigation and enforcement.

## After action: examine recurrence

A removed URL does not necessarily mean the source of distribution has stopped. Track repeat uploads and related sources, with evidence linking each finding. Use the history to adjust monitoring and explain continuing exposure to distribution partners.

**TRACKOWLS PERSPECTIVE**

Decision metrics: first verified leak, high-priority sources, response time by release window, and repeat availability.

03 / OTT & STREAMING

# Protect the catalogue without overstating the loss

An OTT catalogue combines different monetization models, release schedules and audience segments. Exposure needs to be understood at title and episode level before it can be connected to subscription or advertising outcomes.

## Separate distribution patterns

Distinguish copied on-demand files, unauthorized streaming pages, paid pirate services and live retransmissions. Record what was accessible and when. A page advertising a title is a lead to investigate; it is not sufficient evidence of a playable infringing copy.

## Match the monitoring to the catalogue

Agree which premieres, languages, episodes and territories take priority. Track monitored assets as well as findings. Otherwise, a reduction in detections could simply reflect a smaller monitoring scope rather than reduced infringement.

## Study audience effects separately

Subscription conversion, churn and advertising displacement cannot be inferred from URL counts. Where appropriate, compare lawful aggregated business data across relevant periods or groups, accounting for pricing, marketing and changes in legal availability. Explain any remaining uncertainty.

**TRACKOWLS PERSPECTIVE**

Decision metrics: exposure by title, catalogue coverage, recurring operators, confirmed outcomes and separately evaluated subscriber effects.

04 / LIVE SPORTS & EVENTS

# Protect the moment while it still matters

For a live match, concert or ticketed broadcast, the practical value of enforcement depends on the event clock. Operational reporting should show whether action occurred during the monetization window.

## Before the event

Confirm the schedule, territorial rights, authorized feeds, priority platforms and escalation contacts. Define how staff will verify a stream and preserve timestamps. Prepare event-specific rights evidence and agree a process for changing priorities when the broadcast schedule moves.

## During the event

Record detection, verification, submission and confirmation times separately. Prioritize active unauthorized streams according to the agreed criteria. A complaint submission is an action taken; it is not proof that the stream stopped. Check availability again before recording a confirmed outcome.

## After the event

Separate live-window outcomes from delayed removals. Review recurring sources and any blind spots in event coverage. This review should inform the next event's monitoring plan rather than produce a retrospective claim that every removed stream represents a recovered purchase.

**TRACKOWLS PERSPECTIVE**

Decision metrics: time to action, verified live sources, monitored event minutes, live-window outcomes and recurrence.

05 / EXPOSURE PATHWAYS

# Understand the route, not only the URL

A discovery channel, a content host and a retransmitting operator may play different roles. Classifying those roles helps teams select an appropriate response and avoid treating all findings as interchangeable.

## Discovery and promotion

Search results, social posts and public channels can direct audiences to another location. Preserve the referring page and destination. Removing a promotional link may reduce discovery while leaving the hosted content available.

## Hosting and distribution

File hosts, streaming pages and apps may provide the content directly or link to another service. Record the actual accessible location and distinguish it from an advertisement or misleading title. Follow only authorized investigation methods; do not bypass private access controls.

## Repeat operators and linked sources

Record relationships only when supported by evidence, such as a shared contact detail or a directly linked destination. Similar layouts or naming patterns can guide investigation but do not establish common ownership. Keep confidence levels visible in intelligence notes.

> **TRACKOWLS PERSPECTIVE**
>
> An outcome should specify what changed: a listing, a discovery link, a hosted file or an active broadcast.

06 / COMMERCIAL IMPACT

# From exposure to a defensible estimate

The financial question is how much qualified unauthorized consumption displaced paid legal consumption. Answering it requires transparent assumptions, rather than multiplying every detected URL by a retail price.

## Build the baseline

Define the asset, territory, legal offer and measurement period. Estimate qualified unauthorized consumption with a documented method. Remove duplicates where possible and explain unknowns. A URL total alone is not a consumption estimate.

## Model displacement

Estimate the share that would otherwise have used a paid legal option. Consider viewers who already pay, viewers without a relevant legal offer and viewers unlikely to buy. Apply net revenue per transaction or the appropriate contribution for the actual business model, rather than an unrelated headline price.

## Use scenarios and separate costs

Present low, base and high scenarios with their assumptions. Keep investigation and enforcement costs distinct from modeled revenue exposure. To claim incremental revenue from an intervention, compare against a credible baseline and consider other drivers of sales.

**TRACKOWLS PERSPECTIVE**

Qualified unauthorized consumption × estimated legal displacement × net revenue per legal transaction. This estimates exposure, not automatic recovery.

07 / MEASUREMENT FRAMEWORK

# A report that supports decisions

Use a stable reporting cohort and explicit definitions. Changing the denominator, coverage period or meaning of a removal between reports can create misleading comparisons.

## Keep the case stages distinct

Show discovered leads, verified cases, submitted actions and confirmed outcomes separately. Retain a case reference and timestamp for each stage. Deduplicate the source records before presenting totals.

## Publish the limitations

State the agreed monitoring channels and asset list, hours of coverage and any unavailable sources. Give estimates a confidence or uncertainty note. Avoid presenting inaccessible channels as fully monitored.

| Measure | Definition |
| --- | --- |
| Verified sources | Deduplicated URLs or streams confirmed to match the protected asset; keep raw discoveries separate. |
| Response time | Median detection-to-verification and verification-to-submission time, with the measurement window stated. |
| Confirmed removal rate | Confirmed removals divided by verified sources in the same defined cohort; show pending cases separately. |
| Repeat infringement | The share of actioned sources or operators found again within an explicitly defined follow-up period. |
| Coverage | The agreed titles, territories, platforms and event hours actually monitored, including known gaps. |
| Estimated exposure | Reach or consumption estimates with their method and uncertainty; never present them as verified lost sales. |

**TRACKOWLS PERSPECTIVE**

A smaller number supported by consistent definitions is more useful than a larger number that cannot be reconciled.

08 / PROTECTION ROADMAP

# Build a repeatable protection programme

The following sequence is an original TrackOwls planning framework. It is a practical guide, not a promise of particular outcomes or access to every platform.

## Stage 1 / Scope and prepare

Agree the protected assets, rights, territories, channels and event or release dates. Set priority rules, reporting definitions and authorized investigation methods. Collect evidence of ownership and identify the people who can approve escalations.

## Stage 2 / Discover, verify and act

Capture findings in a consistent format. Review the content match and rights position, deduplicate the record and submit through the applicable reporting channel. Preserve submission references and response history. Escalate unresolved cases using the agreed process.

## Stage 3 / Confirm and improve

Recheck availability, distinguish confirmed outcomes from pending cases and examine recurrence. Review coverage against the brief. Use operational findings to adjust priorities, and evaluate commercial impact separately when suitable business data is available.

**TRACKOWLS PERSPECTIVE**

Start with an asset list, ownership evidence, territory map, release or event schedule, priority channels and reporting requirements.

METHODOLOGY & RESEARCH NOTES

# Transparent sources. Clear boundaries.

## What this report is based on

TrackOwls prepared this editorial synthesis using the three publications below. There was no original consumer survey, proprietary traffic measurement or client-results dataset. The sector analysis, reporting framework and protection roadmap are original editorial recommendations.

## Scope and limitations

Traffic, economic-loss and revenue-opportunity measures describe different populations and periods. None is a current India-only piracy loss total. Do not add these figures together, treat them as equivalent or interpret them as results achieved by TrackOwls.

**[1]** MUSO — 2024 Piracy Trends and Insights (published 2025)
https://www.muso.com/

**[2]** U.S. Chamber / NERA — Impacts of Digital Piracy on the U.S. Economy (2019)
https://www.uschamber.com/

**[3]** Synamedia / Ampere — Pricing piracy: the value of action (2021)
https://www.synamedia.com/

Original TrackOwls editorial report · October 2026. External research is attributed for context; no research partnership or affiliation is implied.

**TRACKOWLS PERSPECTIVE**

The goal is a defensible view of exposure and response, rather than the largest possible detection count.